

United States — market analysis and roll-out strategy

Johannes le Roux · Get Lucky Golf Club · 10 September 2026 Sources at the end. Every operator count is from the operator's own site or a franchise disclosure on the date shown. Where I have modelled, the inputs are on the table so they can be argued with.

1. The market in numbers

	FIGURE	SOURCE
Americans who touched golf in 2025	48.1M — 29.1M on-course, 19M off-course only (ranges, simulators, Topgolf)	NGF 2026
Simulator / screen-golf users	8.1M in 2024 , up from 3.6M five years earlier (+126%)	NGF white paper 2025
Who they are	51% are "non-golfers" (no on-course round in 12 months), up from 42% a decade ago; three-quarters say they will return; groups of ~3 per bay; younger and more diverse than the on-course base	NGF
Commercial simulator businesses	1,500+ by late 2025, nearly tripled since 2022; median 4 bays, mean 5.9	NGF / Tabski
Green-grass facilities with simulators	6.5% (private 10.4%, public 5.1%); Midwest 8.4%, North 7.9%, South 4% ; 13% plan to add within 1–2 years	NGF
North America's share of the global simulator market	46.6% of a \$2.1bn 2025 market	Grand View, Jun 2026
Golfers by state	California ~2.8M ; Texas, Florida, New York, Pennsylvania, Illinois and Ohio each >1M ; Florida has the most courses (1,290) and the most rounds	NGF state reports

What a bay actually does. A staffed venue sells ~**1,900 bay-hours per bay a year** (36% blended utilisation), at a **\$55 session** of ~90 minutes with **3 players** and **\$40 of food and drink** — roughly **\$100 per visit** and **\$95k–\$115k of revenue per bay a year** (X-Golf's FY2025 franchise disclosure across 114 outlets: median \$94,970 per simulator). Memberships run \$99–\$299 a month, leagues \$199 a season, corporate buyouts \$2,500–\$6,000.

Seasonality is the shape of this business. Peak season is **November to April at ~50% utilisation** (December 51%); summer runs ~**23%**, September is the trough at 21%. The best month earns 2.6× the worst. Operators' single biggest problem is filling weekday daytime — 57% of weekday bay-hours are 9am–4pm and mostly empty. That is a product opening for us: a 60-second Million Dollar Shot is exactly what a venue wants to sell at 2pm on a Tuesday.

2. Where the bays are — and what the law lets us do there

The three chains publish their footprints. Cross-referenced with the legal tiers in `LEGAL-RESEARCH.md` (● paid \$1 entry · ● opinion first · ● free-to-play only):

Five Iron Golf — 42 US venues, 500+ Trackman bays

TIER	VENUES
24	NY 9 (NYC ×7, Port Chester, Syracuse) · IL 4 (Chicago) · OH 3 (Cleveland ×2, Cincinnati) · MA 2 (Boston) · KY 2 (Louisville) · GA 1 (Atlanta) · FL 1 (Miami) · DC 1 · TX 1 (DFW)
15	PA 5 (Philadelphia ×3, Pittsburgh, Erie) · MI 2 (Detroit) · OK 2 · WA 2 (Seattle) · MN 1 · MO 1 · IN 1 · NV 1 (Las Vegas)
3	CT 1 (Norwalk) · MD 1 (Baltimore) · TN 1 (Nashville)

Five Iron already excludes CT, DE, NV, PA and WA from its own real-money tournaments — our tiers and theirs agree.

X-Golf America — 138 locations, franchised, HQ Torrance CA

TIER	LOCATIONS
~65	IL 17 · OH 10 · MA 8 · WI 8 · NY 5 · TX 5 · FL 3 · NC 2 · RI 2 · CA 1 · GA 1 · DC 1 · KS 1 · ME 1
~55	MI 15 · MN 7 · MO 6 · CO 4 · IA 4 · PA 4 · IN 3 · ND 2 · WA 2 · NE, NH, NJ, OR, UT, NV, ID, AL 1 each
18	MD 5 · TN 4 · VA 4 · SC 2 · CT 1 · AZ 1 · SD 1

X-Golf is the Midwest: Illinois, Michigan, Ohio, Wisconsin and Minnesota are 57 of its 138. It is the franchise that proves the cold-weather thesis, and Michigan (15 venues, ●) is the single biggest reason to get a Michigan opinion early.

Golfzon in the US — 120+ commercial facilities plus owned venues

VENUE	STATE	TIER	NOTE
Golfzon Social Brooklyn, Scarsdale (and a Chicago site)	NY, IL	●	Troon JV; the natural \$1M flagship
Golfzon Range by Leadbetter — Westbury NY; Little Ferry NJ	NY ● · NJ ●		Leadbetter is inside Golfzon Group
CityGolf Nashville — first full 18-hole indoor course in the US, opening late 2026	TN	●	Golfzon's showpiece is in a Red state: it launches on the free-play structure, which is fine — it is a promotion venue, not a volume venue
120+ commercial partners (clubs, ranges, lounges); fastest growth in Arizona (●), Nevada (●), Texas (●)	mixed		Partners on Golfzon's own site: USGA, Pebble Beach, Pinehurst, Troon, Arcis Golf, NGCOA, Georgia PGA, NCPGA, SCPGA, the Metropolitan Golf Association, the Miami Dolphins

Topgolf — 100+ US venues, ~100 bays each, Full Swing inside the Swing Suites

Texas 15, Florida 10, California 6, Ohio 5, Georgia 4, North Carolina 4 — Topgolf's core is Green-state. It is a different product (outdoor range bays, Toptracer) and a later conversation, but the geography is on our side when we get there.

The independents — ~1,300 venues, ~6,000–9,000 bays

Nobody sells to them one by one. They arrive when the platform they run on (Golfzon, Trackman, Full Swing, Foresight, Uneekor) switches the slip on. That is why the platform deals are the strategy and the chains are the pilots.

3. Reading the map

1. **Six of the seven biggest golf states are Green** — California, Texas, Florida, New York, Illinois, Ohio. Only Pennsylvania (🟡) is not. The paid product reaches most of the golfers in America without a single Amber opinion.
2. **The cold-weather engine is half Green, half Amber.** Illinois, Ohio, Wisconsin, Massachusetts and New York are Green; Michigan, Minnesota, Missouri, Pennsylvania are Amber. Two opinions — Michigan and Pennsylvania — unlock 30+ X-Golf and Five Iron venues.
3. **New York and Chicago are where every operator overlaps.** Five Iron (11 venues), Golfzon Social (3), Golfzon Range (2), X-Golf (22 in IL/NY), and both are Green. That is the pilot.
4. **Florida is ours in a way it is not Five Iron's.** AGO 90-58 blesses a fixed, sponsor-funded prize; pooled-entry products have to stay out. Florida has the most courses, the most rounds, Ernie's home, the PGA Show, and Topgolf's second-largest cluster.
5. **The Red states are marketing states, not volume states** — with one exception. Nashville (CityGolf, Five Iron, X-Golf x4, Topgolf) is a real market and it is Red; it gets the free-play structure and a sponsor.
6. **Golfzon's own growth markets are awkward:** Arizona is Red, Nevada is Amber. Texas is Green. Lead the Golfzon conversation with Texas, New York and Illinois volume, not Phoenix.

4. The customer, and the two products in the bay

	THE \$1 SLIP	THE MILLION DOLLAR SHOT
Who	The group of three at 7pm; 51% of them don't play on grass. They spend ~\$100 a visit; \$1 is invisible	The corporate host, the birthday group, the member who just birdied, the Vegas bay. The event buyer is the natural \$1,000 payer — a \$2,500–\$6,000 buyout with one Million Dollar Shot for the guest of honour
When	Every visit — the designated hole appears in the round; a standalone 60-second "Get Lucky hole" mode in the bay menu for walk-ups and daytime	Flagship venues, leagues finals, event packages, the PGA Show floor, a monthly live "Million Dollar Shot" segment
Why they buy	The moment. Every ace becomes a video (Golfzon already auto-captures it) — the content loop is free	The story. Nobody else in the building has a swing at a million
Attach assumption	5% / 10% / 20% of player-sessions (conservative / base / strong). For reference, Five Iron's beta had 1,000 players log 20,000 entries with 65% returning in the month	0.05% / 0.10% of ladder entrants take one shot a year

Selling motions inside the venue: the slip at booking (prepaid bays cancel less — operators like prepaid add-ons), at the bay screen, and through leagues — Five Iron's leagues already run weekly closest-to-the-pin prizes; we are the CTP prize upgrade. Daytime: the Get Lucky hole as the venue's 2pm product.

5. The volume model — a US base, not a Korean one

The investor model's simulator line is Korea-only. This is the US base that should replace it (flagged for `investgetlucky`, not changed here).

Inputs: 1,900 bay-hours sold per bay a year; ~1.5 hours a session; 3 players a bay → **~3,800 player-sessions per bay a year**; one designated-hole opportunity per player-session; Get Lucky \$0.46 per \$1 entry; Tier C \$250 per swing at a 45% session; free-play (Structure B) licence assumed at **\$40 per bay per month**.

	PILOT — JAN-APR 2027	NATIONAL YEAR 1 — NOV 2027-OCT 2028	YEAR 2 — NOV 2028-OCT 2029
Paid bays live (Green states)	160 (Five Iron NYC + Chicago; Golfzon Social)	~1,500 (Five Iron 300 · X-Golf 390 · Golfzon 300 · independents 500)	~3,000
Free-play bays (Amber/Red)	—	~700	~1,500
Player-sessions on paid bays	274k (peak-season share)	5.7M	11.4M
Ladder entries at 5% / 10% / 20%	14k / 27k / 55k	285k / 570k / 1.14M	570k / 1.14M / 2.28M
Get Lucky from the ladder	\$6k / \$13k / \$25k	\$131k / \$262k / \$524k	\$262k / \$524k / \$1.05M
Tier C swings (0.1% of entrants)	~30	570	1,140
Get Lucky from Tier C	\$7k	\$143k	\$285k
Free-play licences	—	\$336k	\$720k
Get Lucky revenue (base case)	~\$20k	~\$740k	~\$1.5M
Operator revenue (base)	~\$13k	~\$340k	~\$680k
Insurer premium written (base)	~\$16k	~\$390k	~\$790k

For scale: the current investor model carries \$346k of simulator revenue in 2028 and \$649k in 2029 on a Korea-only base. The US base at a 10% attach roughly doubles both, and it does so on Green-state venues that exist today.

The pilot is not a revenue event — 160 bays for four months is ~\$20k. It is the ace rate by designated hole, the attach rate by time of day, the Tier C demand test, and the telemetry that prices Santam's rate card. Say that to the operator and the investor before anyone asks.

6. The roll-out — built around the season

PHASE	WHEN	WHAT	WHERE	GATE
0 — Gates and deals	Sep-Dec 2026	Santam indications (500x, 1,000x, Tier C); counsel engaged; US entity, bank and fronting carrier; Ernie sign-off and letters; operator one-pager; SDK scoped with cloudandthings; US trip 1 (Fairfax VA, NYC) in Nov	Cape Town → DC/NYC	G1 Santam indication · G2 Ernie · G3 counsel on the Green states

PHASE	WHEN	WHAT	WHERE	GATE
1 — Launch and paid pilot	Jan–Apr 2027 (the peak season)	The Million Dollar Shot launches at the PGA Show, 26–29 Jan — Golfzon Tour finals on the floor, Ernie dinner. Paid pilot in New York and Chicago : Five Iron's 11 venues, Golfzon Social Brooklyn/Scarsdale/Chicago, Golfzon Range Westbury. Tier C at two flagship venues. Free-play switched on at Five Iron Philadelphia/Detroit if the opinions land	NY, IL (●)	Signed pilot (G4); 90 days of telemetry (G5)
2 — Summer build	May–Oct 2027 (the trough)	Integration on the winning platform's SDK; Michigan and Pennsylvania opinions; X-Golf franchisor deal (Torrance) for the Green-state franchises (IL 17, OH 10, MA 8, WI 8, TX 5, FL 3); Golfzon America commercial partners in TX/NY/IL; free-play into the Amber Midwest; US territory sponsor signed on the Santam template; Korea trip only if Golfzon HQ sponsors it	Green states + free-play Amber	Platform deal signed; sponsor signed
3 — "Million Dollar Winter"	Nov 2027–Apr 2028	National paid launch across the 18 Green states on Golfzon, Five Iron and X-Golf; free-play everywhere else; Golf Channel / Versant content if Full Swing is in; a monthly live Million Dollar Shot with Ernie; leagues CTP integration	18 ● states paid · 33 free	1,500 paid bays; 10% attach
4 — Amber conversions and the next platforms	2028	Convert Amber states as opinions land (MI, PA, MN, MO, WA, NJ, NV); Topgolf/Toptracer and Full Swing Swing Suites; independents via platform switch-on; Korea phase two	—	3,000 paid bays

Two calendar rules: **never launch paid in summer** (the trough hides the attach rate), and **every big moment sits in the season** — PGA Show in January, national launch in November.

7. Who we sell to, in order

PRIORITY	COUNTERPARTY	WHAT THEY GET	FIRST ASK	OWNER
1	Golfzon America (Sean Pyun, Fairfax VA)	The jackpot layer in the bay UI for 120+ US partners and the Social/Range venues; 30% of entries; the U.S. Open story with a two-time champion	90-day paid pilot in NY/IL; the slip in the software	JLR
2	Five Iron Golf (Jared Solomon, NYC)	The insured ace on top of Five Iron Tournaments' \$1 CTP; the Million Dollar Shot in events and leagues	60-day pilot NYC + Chicago; ace data by hole	JLR
3	X-Golf America (franchisor, Torrance CA)	A national promotion its 65 Green-state franchisees can run without buying anything	Franchisor agreement; pilot in Illinois/Ohio	JLR
4	Versant / Full Swing (post-close)	A broadcastable moment for Golf Channel; the prize layer Skill Strike cannot carry; Swing Suites	Content partnership + Swing Suite pilot in Florida/Texas	JLR + Ernie's Golf Channel relationships
5	Trackman (AJ Broderick)	A Trackman-native slip reaching Five Iron and every independent Trackman venue	SDK access once Five Iron data exists	JLR

PRIORITY	COUNTERPARTY	WHAT THEY GET	FIRST ASK	OWNER
6	A US territory sponsor	The Santam model: the balance sheet that underwrites also sponsors; category exclusivity on the Million Dollar Shot	Signed before the November launch	JLR + Indwe

8. What it takes — team, entity, money

NEED	PLAN
US presence	Johannes in the US for the November trip, the PGA Show and the launch month; a US partnerships lead hired by Q2 2027 (New York); ops/claims run from Cape Town with US hours
Entity and rails	A Delaware LLC; a US bank and acquiring relationship briefed on skill-contest merchant categories; a fronting carrier or Lloyd's coverholder for the US risk with Santam Re behind; 1099 reporting
Product	The partner API (bay slip, designated hole flag per course, locked settings, telemetry ingest, claims pack); state geo-gating; the standalone Get Lucky hole mode; Tier C KYC and declaration flow; official rules by state
Money	Twelve months US-first, honest numbers: legal \$120–150k (opinions, rules, entity, contracts) · SDK and partner API \$150–200k · launch marketing and the PGA Show/Ernie moments \$150–200k · travel and US hire \$150k · \$600–700k . The current round allocates R1.2m (~\$65k) to simulator integration; a US-first plan needs the round re-cut or the launch co-funded by the operator's marketing budget and the territory sponsor — both are part of the ask, not an afterthought

9. Risks specific to the US roll-out

RISK	WHAT WE DO
Attach rate is a guess	The pilot measures it at 160 bays before anyone commits a national number
Tier C demand is unproven	Flagship venues and event packages only until the pilot says otherwise
Season timing	Paid pilot Jan–Apr; national launch November; nothing paid launches in summer
Amber states hold a third of the cold-weather bays	Michigan and Pennsylvania opinions in Phase 2; free-play there meanwhile
Skill Strike gets there first on Full Swing	Move on Golfzon and Trackman, where there is no money game; pitch Versant as the prize layer
Payment rails and chargebacks on \$1,000 swings	Prepaid in-app; KYC; the operator's wallet (Lucra at Five Iron) carries the risk framework already
Budget	The R8m round does not fund a US-first launch on its own — say so to the shareholders now and make the operator and the sponsor carry launch marketing

10. The first 90 days, US-specific

1. Send `SANTAM-BRIEF.md` to Indwe (18 Sep) — the US territory question is in it.
2. Engage US gaming counsel with `LEGAL-RESEARCH.md` — Green-state confirmation first, Michigan and Pennsylvania second (30 Sep).
3. Form the US entity; open the bank conversation (Oct).

4. Letters to Sean Pyun and Jared Solomon with the Ernie letter; X-Golf franchisor introduction (Oct).
 5. US trip 1: Fairfax VA, NYC — walk Five Iron Rockefeller Center and Golfzon Social Brooklyn with the pilot term sheet (Nov).
 6. Lock the PGA Show plan: floor presence with the operator, the Ernie dinner, the Million Dollar Shot launch moment (Nov).
 7. Pilot term sheets signed; SDK build starts against the winning platform (Dec).
 8. Rebase the investor model's simulator line on the US inputs above (Dec).
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Sources

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- Topgolf US locations — <https://topgolf.com/us/locations/> ; ScrapeHero count by state (Jun 2026) — <https://www.scrapehero.com/location-reports/Topgolf-USA/>
- Legal tiers: `LEGAL-RESEARCH.md` in this repo. Pricing and tiers: `STRATEGY.md` §6 and `SANTAM-BRIEF.md`.

All amounts in US dollars. Forward-looking volumes are the company's current plan and modelled assumptions, not commitments; the attach rates and free-play licence rate are stated assumptions to be replaced by pilot data. No simulator operator agreement exists as at 10 September 2026. Get Lucky Golf Club (Pty) Ltd · Registration 2025/047585/07 · johannes@getluckygolfclub.com